Exploring the Impact of Qualified Foreign Institutional Investors (QFII) on Corporate ESG Performance: A Cross-Industry Analysis

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Date (dd/mm/yyyy) 25/04/2024

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本科生毕业论文

探讨合格境外机构投资者（QFII）对公司 ESG 绩效的影响：

跨行业分析

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2024 年 4 月 25 日

Statement of Originality

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Exploring the Impact of Qualified Foreign Institutional Investors (QFII) on Corporate ESG Performance: A Cross-Industry Analysis

Abstract: This paper takes the listed companies with QFII shareholding in China's A-shares from 2018Q4-2023Q1 as the research sample to study the impact of Qualified Foreign Institutional Investor (QFII) shareholding on corporate Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) performance. Research indicates a significant positive correlation between the shareholding ratio of QFII and corporate ESG performance. Specifically, an increase in QFII shareholding contributes positively to the enhancement of corporate ESG performance; moreover, there is industry differentiation in the role of QFII on corporate ESG performance, and there are some industries where the increase of QFII shareholding ratio has caused an abnormal increase or decrease in ESG scores.

Key Words: QFII shareholdings; ESG performance; Industry differentiation

探讨合格境外机构投资者（QFII）对公司 ESG 绩效的影响：跨行业分析

摘要： 本文以 2018 年第四季度至 2023 年第一季度中国 A 股市场中拥有 QFII 持股的上市公司为研究样本，研究合格境外机构投资者（QFII）持股比例对公司环境、社会及治理（ESG）绩效的影响。研究表明，QFII 的持股比例与公司 ESG 绩效之间存在显著的正相关关系。具体来说，QFII 持股比例的增加对公司 ESG 绩效的提升有着积极的贡献；此外，QFII 对公司 ESG 绩效的作用在不同行业之间存在差异，部分行业中 QFII 持股比例的增加导致了 ESG 评分的异常增加或减少。

关键字: QFII 持股；ESG 绩效；行业差异

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1.Introduction

1.1.Background and Purpose

With the deepening of globalization and the increasing frequency of cross-border capital flows, the establishment and improvement of the Qualified Foreign Institutional Investor (QFII) system is an important step in opening up China's capital market to the outside world. Since 2002, when the China Securities Regulatory Commission (CSRC) and the People's Bank of China (PBoC) jointly issued the Interim Measures for the Administration of Domestic Securities Investment by Overseas Institutional Investors, the influence of QFIIs in China's capital market has continued to grow, and QFIIs have become one of the indispensable players in the market.

In addition, with the global emphasis on environmental protection, social responsibility and governance (ESG), the concept of ESG investment has gradually become an important consideration for international investment.ESG is not only related to the sustainable development of enterprises but also closely related to the long-term interests of investors. Therefore, exploring the relationship between the QFII shareholding ratio and corporate ESG performance is of great significance in understanding the international influence of the capital market and its role in promoting corporate social responsibility.

1.2.Implications

1.2.1.Theoretical Implications:

By examining the relationship between QFII ownership and corporate ESG performance, this study provides a new perspective for understanding the impact of international capital on corporate social responsibility. In addition, the findings help to deepen the understanding of ESG investment concepts and their application in different industries and provide empirical support for the construction and development of ESG-related theories.

1.2.2.Practical Implications:

For policymakers and regulators, the findings of this study can provide a basis for further improving the QFII system and promoting the healthy development of the

capital market. For investors, understanding the relationship between QFII ownership and corporate ESG performance can help them make more scientific investment decisions and promote the flow of capital to more socially responsible companies. Meanwhile, this study also provides a reference for listed companies to improve their ESG performance and attract international capital, which will help them achieve sustainable development.

1.3.Research Content

This paper takes the QFII shareholding companies listed in A-share companies as the research object and thoroughly analyses the relationship between the QFII shareholding ratio and the ESG performance of companies, and the whole content is divided into five parts.

The first part is the introduction. This part describes the research background of this paper, the research purpose, the research significance, the research content and the research methodology. On this basis, the innovations and shortcomings of this paper are proposed.

The second part is the literature review. This part firstly summarises the investment characteristics and economic results of QFII, the influencing factors of corporate ESG performance and domestic and international studies; secondly, it compiles the relevant literature of previous scholars on the impact of institutional investors on ESG performance, QFII shareholding and corporate environmental protection, and social responsibility and corporate governance.

The third part is the research programme and design. Based on the literature review in the previous part, theoretical analyses are conducted on the impact of QFII ownership on corporate ESG performance and whether there is industry variability in this impact, and the corresponding hypotheses are formulated. The data sources of the study, the methodology and the basis of data selection are explained, followed by the model design and the definition of the selected research variables.

The fourth part is the empirical analysis. This paper shows the statistical analysis in terms of the sample data of the study, after which the correlation between the sample data is tested. After that, regression analysis is carried out and the results of

the regression test are explained in the paper, and in this process, the differences of the industry are taken into account. Finally, to test the results of the empirical evidence, this paper applies the method of robustness test.

The fifth part is the research conclusion and suggestions. The results of the study are summarised and the corresponding suggestions are made to the subjects concerned.

1.4.Research Methodology

This paper adopts a combination of theoretical and empirical analyses to conduct the research.

Theoretical analysis method: this paper reads and collates the previous studies from the economic consequences generated by QFII, the influencing factors of ESG, the influence of institutional investors on the ESG performance of enterprises as well as the influence of QFII in the three aspects of environmental protection, social responsibility and corporate governance, to find theories for the relationship between QFII shareholding and the ESG performance of enterprises, explores the influence of industry differences between the two, and puts forward research hypotheses. and put forward the research hypothesis.

Empirical analysis method: this paper takes the A-share listed companies containing QFII holdings from the fourth quarter of 2018 to the first quarter of 2023 as the research sample, uses SPSS as the research tool, establishes a regression model to study the relationship between QFII holdings and corporate ESG performance and whether there is industry heterogeneity, and conducts a robustness test by using the method of replacing the explanatory variables and the method of adding control variables.

1.5.Contributions and Limitations

1.5.1.Contributions

Most of the existing studies on the influencing factors of corporate ESG performance focus on macro and micro conditions, and a few scholars explore the driving role of corporate ESG from the perspective of institutional investors, but few literatures explore the perspective of QFII shareholding. This paper examines the ESG

performance-enhancing role of QFII shareholding from the perspective of QFII shareholding.

This paper also analyses the industry-specific variability of listed companies with QFII shareholding one by one, further enriching the research on the role of QFIIs in different types of industries and proposing potentially valid analyses to explain the reasons for industry-specific variability, which provides more references for subsequent research.

1.5.2.Limitations

In this paper, the selection of company sample data takes into account relevant factors such as sample size and data availability. First, since QFII-held companies account for only a very small proportion of all A-share listed companies, this paper only evaluates the stocks of all A-share listed companies that include QFIIs but ignores the ESG performance data of listed companies without QFIIs and also does not consider the ESG performance of companies that are still in the listing stage and unlisted companies that include QFII pre-investment.

Regarding the selection of the sample time point of this study, the starting point of the sample selected in this paper is the fourth quarter of 2018, the cut-off point is the first quarter of 2023, and the quarterly data is selected. In recent years, due to the impact of the new crown epidemic and other factors, the sample data may appear different from previous changes, and there are some limitations. In addition, the temporal scope of this paper is limited by the different periods of ESG rating agencies' public data, the results of which may also have some impact on the empirical analyses.

2.Literature Review

With the introduction of QFII in China and the establishment of a series of policies and systems to regulate it, the importance of QFII in China's capital market has gradually increased, and scholars have conducted a series of discussions and studies on the development of QFII in China. Relevant studies include the investment preferences of QFII(Zhang et al. 2017; Xu 2017), the trading behaviour of QFII(Liu et al. 2007; Sun et al. 2019), and the economic effects of QFII, such as the impact on

securities market stability(Zu et al. 2019), corporate innovation(Tan et al. 2020; Zhou et al. 2022), corporate performance(Wang et al. 2013; Ma et al. 2017) and other aspects.

In China, the development of ESG is still in the preliminary stage, and many scholars have gradually expanded their knowledge and understanding of the overall performance of corporate ESG by examining the motives and economic consequences of corporate ESG on the basis of corporate social responsibility. Overall, most scholars at home and abroad are now more inclined to discuss the impact of corporate ESG performance on corporate innovation performance(Li et al. 2021; Wang et al. 2022), cost of debt financing(Lian et al. 2023; Kong et al. 2023), share price risk(Xi et al. 2022; Li et al. 2022) and other aspects. A few scholars, on the other hand, start from the influencing factors and explore, for example, the shareholding structure(Lei et al. 2023; Zhang et al. 2023; Tan et al. 2024) , environmental conditions(Pan et al. 2023; Zhou et al. 2023), party organisation governance(Liu et al. 2022) and digitalisation(Zhang et al. 2023; Wen et al. 2024) and other factors affecting corporate ESG performance.

2.1.Institutional Investors and ESG

A review of previous literature indicates that there are limited studies on the relationship between QFII and corporate ESG performance. Most scholars have focused on the correlation between institutional investors and corporate ESG performance. Bai et al. (2022) discovered that institutional investors can tolerate, to some extent, the low short-term business performance of listed companies with good ESG performance. They also have a certain investment preference for ESG. Chen et al. (2023) and He et al. (2023) found that institutional investors generally hold shares for a longer period to promote corporate governance quality through supervision. And they also convey true information about the company to other investors through the public market, which effectively improves the company's ESG performance. Additionally, listed companies' ESG information disclosure can increase institutional investors' proportion of shares, positively affecting the capital market. On the other hand, disclosing ESG information by listed companies can encourage institutional

investors to increase their shareholdings. This has a positive impact on the capital market and encourages investors to make informed investment decisions, thereby reducing the risk of a stock price collapse.

With regard to QFII, although domestic and international scholars have little to say about the link between QFII and the overall performance of ESG, the role of QFII on each of the three dimensions of ESG performance has been researched accordingly:

2.2.QFII and Environmental Protection

Qualified Foreign Institutional Investors (QFII), as an important part of institutional investors, can effectively encourage investee companies to carry out green innovation and pay attention to environmental protection issues through the image of shareholding, to improve the ESG performance of enterprises. Chen et al. (2010) showed that the greater the pressure from stakeholders such as foreign shareholders, the higher the quality of corporate environmental disclosure. Wang et al. (2017) found that QFII's shareholding will make them prompt listed companies to be more active in green investment and improve their green investment level by participating in corporate governance. Zhu et al. (2019) found that the higher the shareholding ratio of institutional investors, the more favourable it is to alleviate the agency problem and motivate the management to make long-term environmental investments. Guo et al. (2023) find that foreign institutional investors promote the improvement of firms' environmental behaviours by alleviating financing constraints and increasing analysts' attention, while Wang et al. (2023) suggest that institutional investors can significantly promote firms' capitalised environmental investments through internal control compared to expensed environmental investments.

2.3.QFII and Social Responsibility

QFIIs' investment preferences tend to favour enterprises that actively fulfil their social responsibilities，while their shareholding can have a positive effect on the degree of social responsibility disclosure of enterprises. Additionally, QFIIs pay more attention to the long-term sustainable development ability of enterprises compared to other investors. As economic globalisation accelerates and China's QFII policy becomes

more relaxed, foreign investors will have more investment opportunities. Chapple et al. (2005) found that investors from developed regions, such as Europe and the United States, maybe more interested in companies that actively fulfil their social responsibilities. This strengthens the level of corporate social responsibility participation in the Asian region to some extent. Barako et al. (2006) found a positive correlation between foreign investors' shareholding and CSR disclosure. Jing et al. (2009) argued that higher foreign investor shareholding in Sino-foreign equity joint ventures leads to better protection of shareholders' and employees' interests. Furthermore, studies conducted by Li et al. (2008), Oh et al. (2011), Wang et al. (2014), Mcguinness et al. (2016), and Yan et al.(2016) have consistently shown that the shareholdings of foreign investors or QFIIs are influenced by Western management practices. These practices promote the idea of value investment and emphasise the long-term value and sustainable development of the company. Long-term shareholding can provide strong voting rights, giving shareholders the ability to influence management decisions and increase the company's participation in social responsibility, ultimately enhancing its competitive advantage.

2.4.QFII and Corporate Governance

In past studies, many scholars have explored the impact of QFII shareholding on the corporate governance capacity of enterprises through different perspectives. Regarding information disclosure, Li et al. (2005), Chen et al. (2007), and Schnatterly (2008) argue that QFIIs possess more information about firms than other investors. They suggest that QFIIs can encourage voluntary disclosure by municipal firm management, which can help reduce information asymmetry between institutional and individual investors. However, the text does not provide any further details on the problems mentioned. Research suggests that institutional investors' concentrated positions can strengthen management supervision, and improve the dividend payout ratio, profitability of common stock, and willingness to pay cash dividends of listed companies. This effect is more pronounced with a higher proportion of shares held by QFIIs (Li et al. 2006; Wei et al. 2012; Qiu et al. 2014). From a corporate governance perspective, Zhou et al. (2007) and Dong (2007) argue that QFIs possess professional

financial management teams, exhibit rational investment behaviour, and benefit from economies of scale, which will undoubtedly contribute to the improvement of the shareholding structure and board characteristics of listed companies. Conversely, Gao et al. (2008) argue that QFIIs tend to invest in companies with high levels of corporate governance.

3.Research Programme and Design

3.1.Theoretical Basis and Research Hypotheses

3.1.1.QFII shareholding ratio and ESG composite score of enterprises

Combined with the domestic and international existing research base known, there has been a sufficient amount of research between QFII and the investee enterprise's environmental protection, social responsibility participation and corporate governance three factors, most domestic and international scholars believe that QFII can promote enterprises to improve the performance of environmental, social responsibility and corporate governance. From the perspective of ESG scores, this paper argues that there are possibilities for QFII to contribute to the improvement of firms' ESG scores.

First of all, as institutional investors, QFIIs hold a higher proportion of corporate equity than domestic retail investors, and short-term arbitrage or speculative investment strategies do not maximise returns. Meanwhile, domestic entry conditions for QFIIs are stricter, the size of QFII funds is limited, and it is easier for QFIIs to be noticed by the regulators when they conduct securities transactions. Therefore, QFII's investment strategy for A-share listed companies pays more attention to long-term holding, and will not sell the stocks at will. Therefore, when choosing stock targets, QFII will pay attention to the long-term development of the enterprise, give priority to companies with sustainable operation ability in the future, closely combine their interests with the future of the company, actively participate in corporate governance, and further increase their investment in the company.

At the same time, the increase of QFII shareholding ratio has the relevant advantages to help the company to improve ESG, such as (1) QFII shareholding access to the company's development decisions, to guide the company in the strategy set to improve the performance of the ESG objectives (2) QFII shareholding can send

a signal to the market has the value of the investment when the company may be subject to the increase in expenditure on ESG, resulting in the slowing down of financial data QFII holdings can signal to the market that there is value in investing in a company that may experience a slowdown in its financials due to increased ESG expenses, giving other investors the confidence to invest in the company and increasing the determination of the company's management to continue to develop its ESG strategy. QFIIs, as international investment institutions, have advantages that other institutional investors lack: (1) Risk tolerance: QFIIs, as global investment institutions with diversified investments and abundant capital, have strong risk tolerance, which, to a certain extent, can encourage companies to boldly increase their investments and expenditures that contribute to the improvement of ESG performance. (2) QFII as an international institution, and usually has many years of global investment experience, can provide enterprises with foreign companies with environmentally friendly production technology, inculcate the concept of social responsibility and teach advanced governance experience, to improve the company's ESG performance. (3) In addition, QFII can also provide a wide range of human resources, such as the introduction of enterprises to the excellent partner or learning and exchange of objects, recommend or introduce excellent ESG talent. The following hypotheses are put forward in this paper. Based on the above analysis, this paper proposes the following hypotheses:

H1: QFII shareholding is positively correlated with firms' ESG composite scores, which means that the higher the shareholding ratio of QFIIs is, the better the firms' ESG performance is.

3.1.2.QFII shareholding affects the industry-differentiated performance of ESG scores:

Studying the impact of different industries on the relationship between QFII shareholding and corporate ESG performance is important for further understanding the role of QFII. In the context of the national policy of advocating high-quality development, industries involved in generating polluting emissions in the production process will face related environmental issues, and employee production safety issues,

and improving performance in terms of ESG will not only contribute to long-term sustainable development but also create a more positive corporate image and attract more investment, while for industries with high social responsibility and less consideration for environmental protection and corporate governance, continuing to increase the ESG performance does not seem to be an optimal solution for corporate strategy, so there may be variability across industries in the impact of QFII shareholding on corporate ESG performance. In summary, this paper proposes the following hypotheses

H2: The effect of QFII shareholding on firms' ESG composite scores varies across industries.

3.2.Research Design

3.2.1.Sample Selection and Data Source

This paper launches an empirical investigation with the data of A-share listed companies with QFII shareholding, and the sample is processed as necessary. It is worth noting that the ESG scores in this paper are based on the RoyalFlush ESG scores as a reference, and the RoyalFlush ESG database does not cover the data before 31 December 2018, so this paper sets 31 December 2018 to 31 March 2023 as the sample interval. Considering other factors, this paper screens the samples as follows: (1) Excluding insurance, finance, capital service industries, listed companies with missing financial data, and observations of ST and * ST companies; (2) Excluding observations with missing certain control variables. After the above screening, this paper finally obtained 1106 sample data from 616 listed companies. This paper will use SPSS for regression analysis.

The data in this paper comes from the following sources: (1) The original data of the ESG score data of the explanatory variables come from the RoyalFlush ESG database. (2) The data of the main explanatory variable QFII shareholding ratio and the control variables come from the RoyalFlush database.

3.2.2.Model Setting

The constructed model (1) of this paper tests hypothesis 1:

$$ESG_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 QFII_{it} + \beta_2 CAP_{it} + \beta_3 PER_{it} + \beta_4 ROE_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

Where, the dependent variable of model (1) is ESG, which represents the composite score of firms' ESG performance, and QFII is the independent variable, which represents the proportion of QFII shareholding. CAP, PER, and ROE represent the control variables: total market capitalization, price-to-earnings ratio (TTM), and return on equity, respectively, ε represents the random error terms (equivalent below). Further to verify whether the effect of QFII shareholding ratio on ESG scores shows significant differences in different industries, this paper introduces industry variables and the interaction term between QFII shareholding ratio and industry based on model (1) to conduct the test of the interaction effect, the model (2) is shown:

$$ESG_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 QFII_{it} + \beta_2 CAP_{it} + \beta_3 PER_{it} + \beta_4 ROE_{it} + \sum_j \delta_j \, Industry_i + \sum_j \theta_j QFII_{it} \times Industry_i + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (2)$$

3.2.3.Definition and Measurement of Variables

(1)Explained Variable:

The explained variable in this paper is the ESG Score Performance (ESG). At present, domestic and foreign academics measure corporate ESG performance scores mainly by constructing an indicator system for itemised and comprehensive scoring or directly using scoring reports issued by third-party authoritative institutions.

Based on ESG research and practice at home and abroad and the characteristics of the domestic capital market, the RoyalFlush ESG research team has constructed the ESG rating indicator system, rating methodology, indicator data and rating database by using processing technologies such as artificial intelligence, machine learning and natural language, which has a certain degree of professionalism and independence. Therefore, this paper adopts the RoyalFlush ESG rating system as the explanatory variable, effectively avoiding the subjectivity of a self-constructed indicator system. The evaluation system constructs a four-level evaluation index system; under the first-level index, there are two major evaluation dimensions, ESG management practices and ESG controversial events, which realise the comprehensive measurement of enterprises' long-term sustainable development ability and short-term unexpected risk events; each dimension is divided into three topics as second-level

indexes, namely, the environment, society and governance, which realise the effective measurement of the core ESG topics; and there are specific topics as third-level indexes, with 29 items; each topic is divided into three levels, namely, environment, society and governance. Each theme is divided into three topics as Level 2 indicators, environmental and social, and governance, to achieve effective measurement of the core ESG topics; each topic is divided into specific topics as Level 3 indicators, with a total of 29 items; each topic is quantitatively calculated from the corresponding underlying Level 4 indicators, with a total of more than 350 items, and the final calculation is done to obtain the composite ratings and scores. RoyalFlush ESG comprehensive rating results using "C-AAA" three-level nine-grade rating methodology, ESG comprehensive score, second-level score, and third-level score are between 0-100 standard score, the higher the score, indicating that the subject of the evaluation in the performance of the indicator is better. For the convenience of research, this paper adopts the comprehensive score as the indicator of corporate ESG performance.

(2)Main Explanatory Variables:

The main explanatory variable of this paper is the proportion of QFII shareholding (QFII). This paper refers to the research results of Wang et al. (2014)and adopts the ratio of QFII shareholding to the total share capital of the company in each quarterly reporting period.

(3)Moderator Variable:

QFII and industry interaction term is the moderating variable. It is used to test whether the effect of the QFII shareholding ratio on firms' ESG composite scores varies with the industries they belong to. The data in this paper involves a total of 67 industries, i.e., there are 67 interaction terms.

(4)Control Variables:

Concerning previous studies, this paper chooses total market capitation, price-to-earnings ratio (TTM) and return on equity as control variables, while adding industry dummy variables for control.

Total market capitation is the sum of enterprise market value, which is an

indicator of enterprise scale. Controlling this variable can eliminate the influence of enterprise-scale on ESG performance and ensure that the research results are mainly affected by the shareholding ratio of QFII.

Price-to-earnings ratio(TTM) is an indicator of corporate profitability and a major valuation method, reflecting investors' expectations of corporate future earnings, controlling for the price-to-earnings ratio(TTM) can eliminate the impact of investor sentiment on ESG performance and ensure that the research results are mainly affected by the shareholding ratio of QFIIs. TTM in this case is Trailing Twelve Months, a price-to-earnings ratio(TTM) calculation methodology

Return on equity is a measure of the profitability of corporate assets, reflecting the effective use of corporate assets. Controlling for this variable excludes the impact of corporate profitability on ESG performance and ensures that the results of the study are mainly affected by the proportion of QFII shareholding.

Industry is the industrial sector in which the enterprise is located, and different industries have different characteristics and environments. Controlling industry variables can help researchers consider the impact of different industries on the research results to ensure the reliability and generalisation of the research findings. This paper classifies enterprises according to the guidelines of industry classification of the Securities and Futures Commission (new), and the data in this paper totals 67 industries.

The definitions of specific variables in this paper are shown in Table 3-1.

Table 3-1 Definition of the Variables

Variable Type	Variable Name	Variable Symbol	Variable Definition
Explained Variables	ESG Score Performance	ESG	ESG Composite Score
Explanatory Variable	QFII shareholding ratio	QFII	QFII shareholding/outstanding A-shares
Moderator Variable	QFII-industry interaction term	QFII×Industry	QFII × Industry dummy variable

Continued

Variable Type	Variable Name	Variable Symbol	Variable Definition
Control Variables	Total market capitalization	CAP	Total number of shares × Market price per share
	Price-earnings ratio (TTM)	PER	Current share price / Earnings per share over the past 12 months
	Return on Equity	ROE	Profit after Tax / Net Worth
	Industry	Industry	Industry dummy variable

4.Empirical Analysis

This chapter begins with descriptive and correlation analyses, followed by an empirical test of the effect of the QFII shareholding ratio on corporate ESG scores through OLS regression models. Secondly, controlling for industry effects and adding QFII-industry interaction terms, the effect of QFII shareholding on corporate ESG scores is further explored to see if there is any industry variability in the effect of QFII shareholding ratio on corporate ESG scores. Finally, the robustness of the results is tested.

4.1.Descriptive Statistics

Table 4-1 shows the descriptive statistics of the main variables in this paper. The mean ESG score is 64.074, the minimum value is 44.370, and the maximum value is 82.457, which shows that the ESG performance of the sample companies is better on the whole; the standard deviation is 8.007, which is much smaller than the mean level, indicating that most of the companies are more concentrated in their ESG performance, and there is no extreme dispersion phenomenon, but given that there is a large span between the minimum value and the maximum values have a large span between them, indicating that there may still be some variability. In terms of QFII shareholding, the mean value is 1.745%, the maximum value is 16.721%, and the minimum value is 0.0605%, which that indicates that the proportion of QFII shareholding in China's listed firms is relatively low and that China still needs to

further open up the domestic securities market.

Among the control variables, the total market capitalization (CAP) varies greatly, with the maximum value about 1556 times the minimum value and a standard deviation of 1040.377, indicating that there is a large difference in the size of the total market capitalization of the firms in the sample. An examination of the price-earnings ratio of listed firms reveals that the standard deviation is 405.287, which is much larger than the mean value of 58.685, indicating that there is a significant difference in the valuation level of listed firms with QFII holdings in the observed values. The mean value of return on equity is 3.008%, which is a good level of profitability, but the difference between the maximum and minimum values is large, and the standard deviation is 56.803, which is larger than the mean value, indicating that there is a large difference in the profitability performance of the sample companies. Overall, QFII's investment in listed enterprises is extensive, covering investment targets of different enterprise sizes, valuation levels and profitability.

Table 4-1 Descriptive Statistics of Main Variables

Variables	N	mean	sd	median	min	max
ESG	1106	64.074	8.007	63.906	44.370	82.457
QFII	1106	1.745	2.363	0.962	0.0605	16.721
CAP	1106	442.621	1040.377	123.203	8.327	12455.53
PER	1106	58.685	405.287	25.020	-1357.74	10927.915
ROE	1106	3.008	56.803	3.702	-1277.03	61.673

4.2.Correlation Analysis

Table 4-2 shows the results of the Pearson correlation test for the main variables in this paper. As shown in Table 4-2, the correlation coefficient of QFII and ESG score performance is 0.124, which is significantly correlated at 1% level, which preliminarily indicates that there is a significant positive correlation between QFII shareholding ratio and ESG score performance of the enterprise without considering

the influence of other factors, i.e., the higher the shareholding ratio of QFII, the better the ESG performance of the enterprise, and the hypothesis H1 of this paper has been preliminarily verified.

For the control variables, total market capitalization and return on equity are both significantly correlated with corporate ESG score performance at 1% level, with regression coefficients of 0.328 and 0.152 respectively, in addition, PER is detected to be significantly negatively correlated, with a regression coefficient of -0.109, which indicates that the selection of control variables is very necessary. For the correlation between the control variables, it can be seen that the results are not significant, indicating that there is basically no multicollinearity problem between the variables in this paper.

Table 4-2 Correlation Results for Main Variables

Variables	ESG	QFII	CAP	PER	ROE
ESG	1				
QFII	0.124***	1			
CAP	0.328***	0.061**	1		
PER	-0.109***	0.028	-0.021	1	
ROE	0.152***	0.047	0.056*	0.002	1

Note: *, ** and *** mean significant correlation at P < 0.1, P < 0.5 and extremely significant correlation at P< 0.01, respectively

4.3.Regression Test and Result analysis

4.3.1.QFII shareholding and ESG score performance

This paper adopts the OLS model to test the impact of QFII shareholding and ESG score performance through model (1) and verifies whether the impact of QFII shareholding and ESG score performance is industry-specific through model (2), as shown in Table 4-3.

Among them, the first two columns are regressions of QFII shareholding on firms' ESG score performance, the first column is a univariate regression of QFII shareholding ratio, the second column is a multivariate regression by adding three

control variables, namely, total market capitalization, the price-to-earnings ratio (TTM), and return on equity without controlling for the effect of industry variables, the last two columns are regression tests of industry variability of the impacts of QFII shareholding on firms' ESG score performance, and the third column controls for industry variability based on the second column controls for the influence of industry effects, and the fourth column adds the interaction term between QFII shareholding and industry to the regression based on the third column.

From the regression coefficients of QFII in Table 4-3, it can be seen that in the univariate regression, the regression coefficient of QFII shareholding is significantly positively correlated at the 1% significance level. After adding the control variables, the coefficients of the QFII shareholding ratio variable are all significantly positive at the 1% significance level, which indicates that the higher the shareholding ratio of QFIIs, the higher the performance of ESG scores of listed companies, i.e., H1 is verified. Among the control variables, the test results show that the price-to-earnings ratio (TTM) of companies is negatively correlated at a significant level of 1%, which may be because the benefits companies derive from ESG activities are lower than the costs, leading to a lower valuation of the company(Friedman et al. 1971), and there is also a relationship that the current ESG rating system is not perfect and investors rarely rely on ESG performance to make investment decisions when assessing the future valuation of the company. The total market capitalization and return on net assets of companies are significantly and positively correlated with their ESG score performance, i.e. the larger the total market capitalization and the higher the return on net assets of companies, the better their ESG score performance.

Table 1-3 Regression Results of the OLS Model

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variable	ESG	ESG	ESG	ESG
QFII	0.420***	0.345***	0.342***	0.427***
	(4.15)	(3.65)	(3.76)	(3.31)

Continued

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variable	ESG	ESG	ESG	ESG
CAP		0.002***	0.002***	0.002***
		(11.17)	(9.252)	(8.97)
PER		-0.002***	-0.001	-0.001
		(-3.80)	(-1.23)	(-1.15)
ROE		0.018***	0.017***	0.017***
		(4.67)	(4.81)	(4.70)
Industry		NO	YES	YES
QFII×Industry		NO	NO	YES
Constant	63.340***	62.475***	66.117***	65.705***
	(213.12)	(214.44)	(108.199)	(3.31)
N	1106	1106	1106	1106
Adj_R^2	0.014	0.143	0.321	0.337

Note:
(1) *, ** and *** mean significant correlation at P < 0.1, P < 0.5 and extremely significant correlation at P< 0.01, respectively

(2) The coefficient t value is shown in parentheses

4.3.2.Industry differential performance

In the third column of Table 4-3, on the model (1), controlling for the effect brought by industry benefits, the regression coefficient of QFII is slightly smaller than that of the regression coefficient without controlling for the industry, but it is still significantly positively correlated at 1% confidence level, i.e., the improvement of firms' ESG performance scores is related to the increase of QFII shareholding ratio without considering industry differences. The fourth column of Table 4-3 demonstrates the regression results of model (2) (to save space, the full regression results of the interaction term between QFII shareholding and industry dummy variables are not presented in this paper). After adding the interaction term, the regression coefficients of QFII are still all significantly positively correlated at the 1%

confidence level.

To further test whether there is industry variability in the impact of QFII shareholding and ESG score performance, the regression coefficients and significance levels of the QFII-industry interaction terms are examined one by one, and it is found that most of the interaction terms are significantly uncorrelated, but some of the interaction terms are significantly positively correlated or significantly negatively correlated at 5% or 1% confidence level, which suggests that the effect of QFII shareholding on the ESG composite scores of firms may be more significant in the case of QFII shareholding ratio for most of the industries. This suggests that for most industries the effect of QFII shareholding on corporate ESG composite scores may not differ significantly, but in some industries, the effect of QFII shareholding on corporate ESG composite scores is different from that of other industries, and inter-industry variability does exist, so H2 is partially validated.

The analyses conducted on industries with higher significance levels reveal significant variations in the impact of QFII shareholding on firms' ESG composite scores across different industries. This disparity may be attributed to industry-specific environmental, social, and governance challenges and opportunities. To delve deeper into these findings, this paper focuses on the interaction terms of industries with the most positive and most negative representative regression coefficients, as illustrated in Table 4-4.

Table 4-4 Industries with Significant Regression Results for Interaction Terms

Industry	Unstandardized Coefficients	t	Sig
Coal Mining and Washing	70.363	2.65	0.008
Chemical fibre manufacturing	18.738	2.27	0.024
Education	-12.428	-2.30	0.022
Pharmaceutical Manufacturing	-2.246	-2.62	0.009

According to the analysis of the regression results of the interaction terms of representative industries in Table 4-4, it can be seen that the positive effect of QFII shareholding on the performance of corporate ESG scores is most significant in the coal mining and washing industry and the chemical fibre manufacturing industry, with the regression coefficients of 70.363 and 18.738, respectively. Combined with the other regression results of the interaction terms with significant regression results, it can be seen that the regression coefficients of the industries that are heavily polluting or strictly controlling the emissions are generally positively significant, while most of the regression results for industries with high social responsibility and not involved in environmental governance show a significant negative correlation, which may indicate that QFIIs holding a higher proportion of shares in these industries traditionally regarded as highly polluting or risky may push these firms to make more efforts in ESG to improve their image and attractiveness among investors. According to Lin (2022) research, for major emission control industries such as petrochemical, chemical, iron and steel, and non-ferrous metals, an enterprise's own operation will have a certain negative impact on the environment, society and corporate governance, and if the emission-control enterprises themselves pay more attention to their ESG performances, they are more able to benefit from them compared to other industries. In addition, the negative significant interaction terms in Education and Pharmaceutical Manufacturing may indicate that a high proportion of QFII holdings is associated with lower ESG scores in these industries, which are usually considered to be more socially responsible, possibly because these industries already have high ESG standards and further improvement is more challenging, or QFII investment preferences behave differently in these industries.

Therefore, this paper concludes that there is no significant difference between industries in the overall impact of QFII holdings on ESG scores, but for some industries, some variability does exist, and hypothesis H2 is tested.

4.4.Robustness Test

4.4.1.Changing the Explained Variables

To ensure the robustness of the regression results of this study and avoid the impact of

ESG evaluation standards of different institutions on the empirical results, this paper selects the Chindices ESG score data to replace the RoyalFlush ESG score data in the previous section, and the robustness test regression results after replacing the explanatory variables are shown in Table 4-5.

Table 4-5 Regression Results After Changing the Explained Variables

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variable	ESG(Chindices)	ESG(Chindices)	ESG(Chindices)	ESG(Chindices)
QFII	0.051***	0.046***	0.033**	0.005
	(3.28)	(3.04)	(2.175)	(0.256)
CAP		0.000***	0.000***	0.000***
		(3.86)	(4.07)	(3.04)
PER		-0.001**	-0.000**	-0.000**
		(-3.24)	(-2.16)	(-1.88)
ROE		0.002***	0.001**	0.001***
		(2.66)	(2.21)	(10.81)
Industry		NO	YES	YES
QFII×Industry		NO	NO	YES
Constant	4.557***	4.523***	4.648***	5.527***
	(99.61)	(94.50)	(44.87)	(19.21)
N	1106	1106	1106	1106
Adj_R^2	0.009	0.036	0.168	0.228

Note:

(1) *, ** and *** mean significant correlation at P < 0.1, P < 0.5 and extremely significant correlation at P< 0.01, respectively

(2) The coefficient t value is shown in parentheses

Table 4-5 shows that the regression results before and after replacing the explanatory variables are basically the same, with the regression coefficients of QFII remaining significantly positive at the 1 per cent level in the first three columns. However, in the fourth column, the regression coefficient of QFII is significantly uncorrelated, and this change may be caused by the different evaluation systems

among institutions. After checking the regression coefficients and significant levels of the interaction terms between QFII and industries, it is found that the regression results after replacing the explanatory variables are still basically the same as the previous paper, with most of the interaction terms of the industries showing irrelevance, while some of the industries are different, which still shows that the regression of this paper is more robust.

4.4.2.Adding Control Variables

Drawing on the robustness method of Rao (2022), and referring to the research results of Zhao et al.(2022) and Bu et al. (2023) , this paper adds control variables that measure the shareholding structure and operation of enterprises in the robustness:

Top 10 shareholders' shareholding ratio (top10): the sum of the shareholding ratio of the top ten shareholders of the company.

Debt-to-asset Ratio (Lev): the total liabilities divided by the total assets at the end of the year.

Year-on-year growth rate of total operating income (Growth): the ratio of the growth of total assets at the end of the year to the total assets at the beginning of the year.

Table 4-6 Regression Results After Adding Control Variables

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variable	ESG	ESG	ESG	ESG
QFII	0.420***	0.373***	0.348***	0.435***
	(4.15)	(3.95)	(3.84)	(3.38)
CAP		0.002***	0.002***	0.002***
		(11.09)	(9.252)	(8.96)
PER		-0.002***	-0.001	-0.001
		(-3.53)	(-1.06)	(-1.05)
ROE		0.018***	0.016***	0.017***
		(3.82)	(4.12)	(4.70)

Continued

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variable	ESG	ESG	ESG	ESG
top10		0.056***	0.033**	0.042***
		(3.76)	(2.19)	(2.65)
Lev		-0.007	-0.003	-0.003
		(-0.78)	(-0.70)	(-0.28)
Growth		-0.006*	-0.005	-0.005
		(-1.87)	(0.12)	(-1.59)
Industry		NO	YES	YES
QFII×Industry		NO	NO	YES
Constant	63.340***	59.217***	64.144***	62.432***
	(213.12)	(52.43)	(51.47)	(27.75)
N	1106	1106	1106	1106
Adj_R^2	0.014	0.156	0.368	0.342

Note:

(1) *, ** and *** mean significant correlation at P < 0.1, P < 0.5 and extremely significant correlation at P< 0.01, respectively

(2) The coefficient t value is shown in parentheses

Robustness test regression results are shown in Table 4-6. According to the table, it can be seen that after adding new control variables, the regression coefficients of QFII are still positive at a 1% significant level, and the test results of the interaction term coincide with the previous article to a high degree, and the significance of the rest of the control variables and their directions remain consistent with the previous article. Among the newly added variables, the proportion of shares held by the top ten shareholders (top 10) turns out to be significantly positive at the 1% level, which suggests that the concentration of shareholding has a positive effect on the performance of firms' ESG scores. In addition, the regression results of the control variables: debt-to-asset Ratio (Rev) and year-on-year growth rate of total operating income (Growth) are not significant, probably because these financial indicators have less impact on ESG performance among QFII shareholding firms, or the firms in the

sample do not have much variance in these two financial indicators, which leads to statistical insignificance.

In conclusion, the regression results of the robustness test support the previous regression results, so the empirical results of this paper are more robust.

5.Conclusion and Suggestions

5.1.Conclusion

This paper selects 616 A-share listed companies with QFII shareholding from 31 December 2018 to 31 March 2023 and adopts the quarterly ESG composite scores published by the RoyalFlush ESG database to measure the ESG performance of the sample companies, and the QFII shareholding ratio applied in measuring the ESG composite scores of the companies, and takes the total market capitalization, the price-to-earnings ratio (TTM), and return on equity as control variables.We study the impact of QFII shareholding ratio on corporate ESG performance, and the empirical results support the previous hypothesis and pass the robustness test. Meanwhile, this paper also controls for the industry effect and adds the interaction term between the QFII shareholding ratio and industry to further examine the impact of the QFII shareholding ratio on corporate ESG performance in different industries. On top of the previous findings, this paper summaries the conclusions drawn:

First, the higher the QFII shareholding ratio, the better the ESG performance of listed companies. The robustness test supports the research conclusions obtained from the benchmark regression. The reason for this may be that when the shareholding ratio of QFIIs increases, they are motivated to actively promote the long-term development of investee companies, and their initiative to obtain more dividends and improve the performance of the company increases, and they begin to transfer advanced ideas and production technologies to investee companies, so that the awareness of environmental protection and social responsibility of the companies will be likely to be strengthened, and the level of corporate governance will be optimised. In addition, to reduce the risk of investee companies facing controversial events and avoid an unexpected decline in the company's stock price, QFIIs may also be inclined to help companies improve their ESG performance to preserve their investment funds.

Second, the impact of QFII shareholding on the overall ESG scores of companies does vary among some industries. For listed companies in industries that are heavily polluted and restricted in emissions, the higher the QFII shareholding, the more positive the impact on ESG performance; for listed companies in industries that are not involved in environmental protection and are socially responsible, the increase in QFII shareholding negatively affects ESG performance. The paper speculates that QFIIs in heavily polluting industries hurt ESG performance. This paper speculates that enterprises in heavily polluted industries face pressure from national policies and need to carry out environmental protection transformation, and the improvement of environmental protection, social responsibility and corporate governance performance can reflect the sustainable development of the company in the future, and in the long run, a high proportion of QFII's shareholding in these industries is likely to push these enterprises to pay more attention to ESG performance and ensure that they have the possibility of long term operation and production, as well as to improve their In the long run, QFII's high shareholding in these industries is likely to push these companies to pay more attention to their ESG performance, ensuring that they have the potential for long-term operation and production while improving their image and attractiveness in the eyes of investors, which will help them attract more capital and thus increase the value of their companies. On the other hand, in industries that are usually considered to have a higher social responsibility and fewer environmental issues involved in the production process, enterprises attach importance to ESG performance for a long time and already have higher ESG standards, and further enhancement may not be able to obtain more economic returns, therefore, QFIIs may have a fixed image and psychological expectations, which reduces the likelihood of helping enterprises to improve their ESG scores, and their investment preferences may differ in these industries.

5.2.Suggestions

(1)For Financial Regulators and Policy Makers

Based on the results of this paper, to achieve high-quality development of enterprises, the relevant government departments can improve the relevant system of QFII

participation in the governance of listed companies by appropriately relaxing the policy restrictions of QFII, which will help to increase the shareholding ratio of foreign investors in China's listed companies and to become an active investor and shareholder of the company, reduce the short-term speculative behaviours, and participate more in the decision-making of the company's long-term development. In addition, QFIIs can be provided with more favourable investment policies for enterprises in heavily polluting and strictly emission-control industries, to encourage them to invest more in these industries and help them invest in and improve their environmental protection, social responsibility and governance structure.

In addition, the financial regulatory government should strengthen the supervision and management of ESG of listed companies, for example, continue to develop internationalised ESG information disclosure standards and principles, and incentivise companies to strengthen the disclosure and transparency of ESG information, to help QFIIs and other investors to better assess the ESG performance of companies, and thus promote the healthy development of the capital market and the sustainable development of companies. At the same time, it should establish a perfect ESG information disclosure reward and punishment mechanism, supporting the necessary incentives and constraints, which is not only conducive to a more scientific and reasonable judgement by the regulatory authorities but also effectively promotes the high-quality and sustainable development of enterprises.

(2)For QFIIs

For QFIIs, this finding emphasises the positive role they play in promoting CSR and sustainable development. As multinational investors, QFIIs not only focus on financial returns but also play a key role in driving companies to improve their ESG performance. This suggests that QFIIs can further promote the practice of CSR by choosing to invest in companies with better ESG performance, while also generating long-term stable returns for their own portfolios. At the same time, when making investment choices based on ESG performance, QFIIs need to consider the impact of industry effects, such as for companies with heavy pollution and strict emission control, listed companies with good ESG scores may be better investment targets,

while for listed companies with good ESG performance in the industry as a whole, they should pay attention to other aspects of the performance of the company to make investment decisions.

(3)For listed companies

The findings of this paper emphasise the importance of QFII in enhancing ESG performance. Enterprises should improve the company's equity structure and dividend distribution mechanism, and actively attract QFII's investment, to improve ESG performance and play its role in the long-term development of enterprises. In addition, enterprises should pay attention to their own investment and operation management in ESG. For example, they should: 1. Form a green and sustainable awareness of environmental protection, make full use of production resources, reduce waste in the production process, and pursue the realisation of high-quality development; 2. Enhance the awareness of social responsibility, and actively fulfil their social responsibilities; and 3. Improve the corporate governance system, and ensure that the company's decision-making is scientific and standardised.

By industry, for those companies located in heavily polluted or emission-restricted industries, improving ESG performance not only helps attract more QFII investment but also improves the company's public image and reduces potential operational risks, thus gaining an advantage in the fierce market competition. Meanwhile, for those enterprises in non-heavy polluting industries, more attention and balance between ESG performance and investor expectations are needed to avoid potential negative impacts caused by higher QFII shareholding, or increased investment in ESG aspects in the context of otherwise higher ESG performance, which could result in unnecessary expenses and lower QFII's investment propensity.

Acknowledgement

As I conclude my undergraduate journey, I find myself reflecting on the completion of this thesis—a significant milestone in my academic path and a pivotal moment in my personal development. The journey to this point has been enriched and made possible by the unwavering support and assistance of many individuals, to whom I owe my heartfelt gratitude.

Foremost, I extend my profound thanks to my thesis advisor, Mrs Chen Shuo. Mr. Chen's invaluable academic guidance and emotional support have been instrumental in my growth. Throughout the thesis writing process, Mr. Chen's patience and assistance enabled me to navigate and overcome numerous challenges. For his tireless teaching and generosity, I am eternally grateful.

I also wish to express my gratitude to all the educators who have guided me throughout my university years. Your teachings have lit my way with the torch of knowledge, shaping me with a commitment to scholarly excellence and inspiring a relentless pursuit of discovery in the vast seas of academia.

My deepest appreciation extends to my parents, whose unconditional love and support have endowed me with the courage to chase my dreams. In times of adversity and doubt, your words of encouragement and solace have restored my confidence. Your unwavering support and understanding form the bedrock of my resilience, and I am profoundly thankful for your nurturing.

Lastly, I am grateful to my peers for their companionship throughout this academic expedition. Together, we have shared countless hours of study, debate, and progress, creating memories that I cherish. The bonds of friendship we've forged are invaluable treasures that I hold dear.

In closing, I reiterate my sincerest thanks to everyone who has contributed to my undergraduate experience. Your influence has imbued my journey with purpose and transformed me into the person I am today. As I look forward to the future, I am committed to persevering, staying true to my principles, and striving for excellence in both my academic pursuits and personal endeavors. Thank you, once again, to all.

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